

The Muse Curriculum

Where each day's poem, passage and painting come from, how they're chosen, what we're allowed to show, and three days worked out from start to finish.

“We walk by great things without appropriate pause and contemplation.”

— from the founder's *Why Poiesis*

MADE FOR
25 • 26 • 27
SEPT 2026

Prepared 24 September 2026 for Niko Kyritsopoulos, founder. Calendar: Greek Orthodox (Revised Julian), with Catholic parallels. Every work quoted here is in the public domain in both the United States and Europe; every story is sourced on the last page.

CONTENTS

- i The method we're borrowing: one priest, one booklet
- ii How a day is built: from the reading to three muses
- iii Meditating on the spine
- iv The selection criteria
- v Where the works come from: sourcing and copyright
- vi Collecting: the Muse Bank and the curator's calendar
- vii Three days: Fri 25, Sat 26, Sun 27 September 2026
- viii Open questions and sources

What this guide settles

The decisions log leaves two things open: *who picks the daily three, and how themes are chosen*. This guide answers the second one fully and gets the first one started. It turns your mission statement and the School of Community booklet into a repeatable routine: a curator could follow it on an ordinary Tuesday and produce a day that feels made by hand.

Decided in this round

- **The Orthodox calendar leads** (GOARCH, Revised Julian). Catholic readings appear as a parallel note.
- **The liturgy is a hidden scaffold**. The day's reading shapes the theme but isn't printed on the Muse page.
- **A small cross (†) sits beside the theme word** when the theme is revealed, on desktop and phone. Tapping it opens the day's Scripture.
- **Arc: the liturgical season plus a "spine" book**, and the spine is something we meditate on, not a list we fill in.
- **Rights: a public-domain core plus a few licensed works**.
- **Your four first-impression questions become the curator's four tests**, plus one "go deeper" line per work that appears after you've written.
- **The reflection goes in the next morning's letter**, so each muse is met cold first.

What it doesn't change

- Three muses a day: poem, passage, painting, in that order.
- The locked prompt: "*How does this muse call to your own experience? What do you hear it singing?*" with "*One sentence is enough.*"
- The BeReal-style gate, links between works, stickers, and no public counts.
- Faith stays implicit and ecumenical *on the page*. The cross is the one door to the liturgy, and it's opt-in.

One consequence: desktop currently shows no theme word, so putting the cross beside the theme means desktop gets the same reveal-after-all-three that phones already have. Log it as a Round 8 decision.

One priest, one booklet

The GS booklet *Expect the Unexpected* works because it's a **journey, not an anthology**. The priest took a single thinker, Luigi Giussani, and followed the order in which Giussani's thought unfolds. At each turn he named the step in one plain word, wrote a few sentences in his own voice, and then went looking for texts that let you *feel* that word, not texts that explain it.

The arc he drew

my longing is my pledge → ignited by another → not satisfied → recognition → boredom → giving up → what I desire → reborn → anxiety → another world → mystery → not afraid → available → ordinary

Read in order, those words tell one story: *I want → I can't satisfy it myself → I'm tempted to give up → I'm met → I can live the ordinary day open-handed*. None of the texts he chose would carry that story alone. The order does.

The anatomy of one of his themes

1 • The word. Lowercase, plain, taken from experience rather than doctrine: *boredom*, not *acedia*.

2 • His voice. A few sentences in his own words that paraphrase Giussani and never quote him at length. (That matters for copyright; see section v.)

3 • Two or three witnesses. A prose anchor (Leopardi, Tolstoy, Lewis), then a poem on a dot-grid page with room to write. Famous and unknown names are mixed on purpose, so Leopardi sits next to a folk-song lyric.

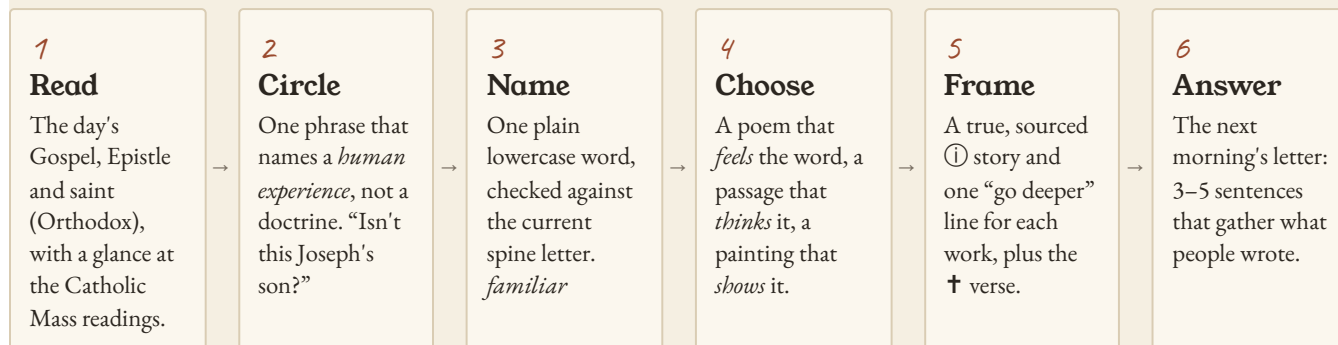
What Poiesis keeps, and what it changes

THE BOOKLET	POIESIS	WHY
One thinker's arc (Giussani)	The liturgical season sets the mood; a spine book for each season sets the arc; the day's reading decides which step lands today.	A daily app needs a calendar that renews itself. The Church year gives you one that has been refined for centuries.
Reflection first, then texts	Texts first. The reflection comes in the next morning's letter .	Pillar 1: the work should spark the reader's own imagination. A reflection read first tells people what to hear.
Theme printed as a heading	Theme word revealed after all three first impressions , with the † beside it.	The mystery shouldn't be scared off by labels (pillar 5), and recognising the word should feel like a small discovery.
Prose anchor and poem	Poem, passage, painting: heart, mind, eye.	Three angles make three kinds of link possible between them.
Printed for a group that meets in person	Published to strangers, possibly paid.	Copyright rules change completely. The booklet's Mary Oliver and Rilke pages would need permission in an app.

One tension to keep in view. The booklet argues toward faith; Poiesis promises a *gift of imagination*. Borrow his **structure** (arc, word, witnesses), not his **stance** (a reflection that concludes for you). So the reflection waits a day.

From the reading to three muses

Every day passes through the same six steps. The first three are quiet work at the curator's desk that the user never sees. The last three are what the user meets.



Three layers of time

The year

The Orthodox Church year begins on **1 September** (the Indiction). Fixed feasts fall on the civil date under the Revised Julian calendar GOARCH uses. The **moveable cycle** hangs on Pascha, which in 2027 falls on **2 May** (Catholic Easter is 28 March), so the two traditions' Lents diverge by five weeks next spring.

The season

Each season gets a mood and a spine book (section iii). The mood sets the *palette* of themes: waiting, hunger, light, labour. The spine sets their *order*.

The day

The reading picks which step of the spine lands today. When a great feast arrives, the feast wins and the spine waits. When the reading is thin, the spine leads. Mid-September's "Lukan jump" (Gospel readings switch to Luke after the Sunday after Holy Cross) is why this week's Gospels come from Luke 4 and 5.

Why three works, and why these three roles

SLOT	FACULTY	WHAT IT MUST DO	COMMON FAILURE
Poem	The heart: <i>feeling</i> the word	Give the experience from inside. Short enough to read twice in one sitting.	A poem <i>about</i> the theme that never makes you feel it.
Passage	The mind: <i>thinking</i> or <i>telling</i> the word	An argument, scene or letter that pushes back on the poem or deepens it.	An inspirational quote with no context. It has to be a real passage.
Painting	The eye: <i>seeing</i> the word	Show the word without saying it. Often the most implicit of the three.	A painting chosen only because its title matches.

Rule of thumb: if someone could guess the theme word from any *single* work, the day is too obvious. They should only be able to guess it from all three together, and then think "*of course*."

The spine is a map, not a menu

A spine is the book whose *order of thought* gives a season its arc. We almost never show it. The priest never reprinted Giussani; he walked Giussani's path and filled it with other voices. That's also what keeps it legal: **ideas, themes and sequences aren't protected by copyright, only the wording is.** So a spine can be a book still under copyright, as long as we paraphrase and never reproduce it.

How to choose one: five questions to sit with

1. **Is it a journey?** Can you tell its argument as a story with a turn in it (want → fail → be met), or is it a list of good things?
2. **Does it speak from experience?** Can every step be named in a word a sixteen-year-old uses about their own life? *Boredom* passes. *Theosis* doesn't, yet.
3. **Does it hold the muse?** Does it respect inspiration as something that *happens* and can't be manufactured, while still valuing formation, judgment and craft?
4. **Can it be split into 20–60 steps?** A season lasts six to ten weeks. Steps can repeat. They shouldn't have to be invented.
5. **Does it fit the season's mood?** Lent wants hunger and ascent. The Nativity Fast wants waiting. The new year wants a call.

How the priest probably did it, as a method

Read it whole, once, fast. Don't mark anything. Afterwards, write one paragraph: *what happened to me as I read?*

Read it again, slowly, with a pencil. Put a mark in the margin wherever the book *turns*: where the reader is meant to feel something new.

Name each turn in one word. Lowercase, from ordinary life. Write the words on index cards.

Lay the cards out as a path and read them in order aloud. If the path tells a story, you have a spine. If it's a heap, cut until it does.

Only then go hunting for witnesses, in the Muse Bank first and in the library second.

Pushback on the mission statement. The mission mixes two spines that don't sit together easily: the *muse* (inspiration, genius, making things) and *the religious sense* (desire, longing, being met). They are related, but a season that tries to do both becomes a heap. My suggestion: alternate them across the year and let the liturgy stitch them together. The table on the next page does this.

One spine per season: proposals to meditate on, not decisions

SEASON & DATES	SPINE	WHY IT FITS	RIGHTS OF THE SPINE
New year → Nativity Fast 1 Sep – 14 Nov	Rilke, <i>Letters to a Young Poet</i> (10 letters, 1903–08)	The Church year opens and so does the call: <i>go into yourself; must I create?</i> These are your own words from the mission, “ <i>follow your heart and recognise its longing.</i> ” Three of the letters were written from Rome.	GREEN German original is public domain; we translate it ourselves
Nativity Fast 15 Nov – 24 Dec	Giussani, <i>The Religious Sense</i>	Forty days of waiting, walked on the priest's own path. It honours where Poiesis came from.	MAP ONLY in copyright; paraphrase, never quote at length
Nativity → Triodion 25 Dec – 20 Feb	Augustine, <i>Confessions</i> (13 books)	The restless heart meets the Word made flesh. The Theophany light carries through the winter.	GREEN Pusey translation (1838)
Triodion & Great Lent 21 Feb – 24 Apr 2027	John Climacus, <i>The Ladder of Divine Ascent</i> (30 steps)	The Orthodox Lenten book: read in monasteries during the fast, and its author is remembered on the 4th Sunday of Lent. Thirty rungs make thirty theme words.	MAP ONLY modern translations in copyright
Holy Week → Pentecost 25 Apr – 20 Jun	Dante, <i>Purgatorio</i> → <i>Paradiso</i>	From Palm Sunday through Pascha to the descent of fire: climbing into light, with Dante's own invocations of the Muse along the way.	GREEN Longfellow translation (1867)
After Pentecost 21 Jun – 31 Aug	The Muse itself: a spine built from your mission	Hesiod on Helicon · Plato's <i>Ion</i> and <i>Phaedrus</i> · Homer's and Virgil's invocations · Milton's “Heavenly Muse” · Keats (<i>negative capability</i>) · Henry James (“ <i>one of the people on whom nothing is lost</i> ”) · Eliot's “Tradition and the Individual Talent” · Abloh's small improvement. Ordinary time: formation.	MOSTLY GREEN Eliot and Abloh QUOTE-ONLY

This season's spine, step by step

Rilke's ten letters to Franz Xaver Kappus, each reduced to one theme word. A curator may use any step on any day when the reading calls for it. The order is the season's *tendency*, not a strict schedule.

#	WRITTEN	THE TURN	WORD
1	Paris, 17 Feb 1903	“Go into yourself.” Ask whether you <i>must</i> write; everyday life is never poor to the one who creates.	<i>within · familiar</i>
2	Viareggio, 5 Apr 1903	Beware irony; keep a few books close (the Bible, Jacobsen).	<i>companions</i>
3	Viareggio, 23 Apr 1903	To be an artist is to ripen like a tree. “Patience is everything.”	<i>ripening · deep</i>
4	Worpswede, 16 Jul 1903	“Love the questions themselves.” Solitude; the body's creativity.	<i>questions</i>
5	Rome, 29 Oct 1903	Rome as a museum, and the few living things beneath it: water, gardens, stairs.	<i>beauty</i>
6	Rome, 23 Dec 1903	Solitude at Christmas; God as the one who is <i>coming</i> .	<i>coming</i>
7	Rome, 14 May 1904	“For one human being to love another: that is perhaps the most difficult of all our tasks.”	<i>beloved</i>
8	Borgeby gård, 12 Aug 1904	Sadness as the moment something new enters us.	<i>sadness</i>
9	Furuborg, 4 Nov 1904	Doubt can become a good quality if you train it.	<i>doubt</i>
10	Paris, 26 Dec 1908	“Art too is only a way of living.”	<i>living</i>

What earns a place

Every work passes **four gates** (pass or fail), then **four tests** (scored), and every day passes **four checks** as a set of three. The four tests are your own first-impression questions, turned around so the curator asks them first.

The four gates (fail one and the work is out)

1 • Clear. The rights are green, or amber with a written permission on file (section v). “Probably fine” is a fail.

2 • True. The ⓘ story is true and confirmed by two independent sources. The text is proofed against a first edition or a scholarly edition, not a quote site.

3 • Whole. It stands on its own and can be read in one sitting. Poems up to about 40 lines, or a self-contained excerpt marked with an ellipsis. Passages of 40–350 words. The painting has to read at phone width.

4 • True in the other sense. It reaches a truth that someone has lived. Clever isn't enough, and neither is propaganda. Despair is allowed only when the day as a whole opens a door, the way the booklet set Flaubert beside Rilke.

The four tests (score 0–2 each; keep a work at 5 or more, with no zero on Encounter)

TEST	THE CURATOR ASKS...	0 • 1 • 2
Encounter	Does it speak to truths people have <i>personally</i> met? Could a stranger answer the locked prompt in one honest sentence?	abstract • someone could • almost anyone
Reality	Does it say something about the reality in front of the reader <i>today</i> : their room, their work, their people?	distant • by analogy • directly
Tension	What question, tension or problem does it raise? Works with no friction produce comments like “so beautiful ♥”.	none • one • it argues with you
Kinship	How does it relate to other works: the spine, Scripture, the Muse Bank? Can it be linked to its two neighbours?	island • one bridge • many

The four day checks

- **Three angles.** Heart, mind, eye. No two works do the same job in the same way.
- **One friction.** At least one side of the day disagrees with another (Barrett Browning's blackberry-pickers against Chesterton's “do it again”), so the links have something to work on.
- **The reveal lands.** Once the word appears, the reader thinks “*of course*,” not “*oh, I see*.”
- **The scaffold holds.** The day works for someone who never taps the †.

Balance across each week

At least two eras and one century before 1600 • **at least two women's voices** • one Eastern Christian voice (Greek, Russian, Syriac, Coptic) • one voice from outside the West • one *discovery*, meaning a work on nobody's syllabus. Aim for roughly **70% canon**, **30% discovery**. That's the booklet's Leopardi-and-a-folk-singer instinct, written down as a number.

An honest range check on the three sample days. They have one woman (Barrett Browning), one Eastern voice (Dostoevsky) and no non-Western work. They pass as three days, but the rest of the week needs another woman (Julian of Norwich, *love was his meaning*) and a voice from outside Europe.

Sourcing and copyright

Poiesis will publish to strangers, may charge patrons, and puts each work *whole* beside a writing box. That's close to the hardest case for “fair use”, so fair use can't be the plan. The plan is a public-domain backbone, a short list of licensed works, and links out for everything else. (This is a working guide, not legal advice. Have a lawyer look at the licensing templates before launch.)

The two-date rule (for 2026; both lines move forward a year every 1 January)

United States

Works **published before 1 January 1931** are in the public domain. Works from 1930 entered it on 1 January 2026. Works from 1931 enter on 1 January 2027.

Europe and most of the world

Life of the author plus 70 years: the author (and **translator**) must have **died before 1 January 1956**. You're in Rome and users will be everywhere, so Poiesis should meet both rules.

Green means both dates pass. Some examples: T. S. Eliot's “Tradition and the Individual Talent” (1919) is public domain in the US, but Eliot died in 1965, so it's protected in Europe until 2036 (**AMBER**). Kazantzakis died in 1957, so his Greek originals become public domain in life-plus-70 countries on 1 January 2028. C. S. Lewis died in 1963, and his post-1930 books are still protected in the US for 95 years from publication.

Translations are a second copyright

A public-domain original doesn't make a modern translation free. Rilke's German is public domain; the Macy-Barrows and Mitchell translations aren't. There are two ways through:

- **Use old translations that are themselves public domain:** Garnett's Dostoevsky (1912), Longfellow's Dante (1867), Jowett's Plato, Common's Nietzsche (1909), Grace Warrack's Julian of Norwich (1901).
- **Make Poiesis translations.** Translate public-domain originals yourself (German, Greek, Latin, Italian) or commission a translator. The translation then belongs to Poiesis. It becomes a signature asset and a reason people come, and the rights are clean. The Rilke lines in this guide are drafted this way.

The three tiers

TIER	WHAT'S IN IT	HOW WE USE IT
GREEN	Public-domain text in a public-domain translation (or our own); paintings from open-access museums; public-domain Scripture translations.	Use freely as a muse. Cite the edition and source link on the Muse Card.
AMBER	Works still in copyright where we can realistically get permission: modern poets, recent translations, the “map-only” spines.	As a muse only with written permission on file . Without it, the letter may quote a line or two <i>inside our own commentary</i> , attributed and never the whole poem.
RED	Song lyrics, whole modern poems without a licence, museum images with restrictive terms, anything whose source we can't verify.	Don't use. Link out (Poetry Foundation, the museum's page) from the letter if it matters.

Why fair use isn't the plan. US law (17 U.S.C. §107) weighs four things: the purpose (commercial use counts against you, commentary helps), the nature of the work (creative works are protected most), the amount (a whole poem is the maximum), and the effect on the market (a free full poem competes with the book). A paid app showing a whole modern poem loses on three of the four. A single line quoted in a critical reflection is a different case. Europe's quotation exception is narrower still.

Paintings: the end of the colour-study era

The prototype shows paintings as labelled colour studies “until real images are licensed or hosted.” For public-domain paintings, no licence is needed. Several great museums release images of their public-domain works under CC0 (no rights reserved, commercial use allowed):

MUSEUM	TERMS	ESPECIALLY STRONG FOR
The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York	CC0; over 492,000 images of public-domain works	Everything, and especially icons, Byzantine art, European painting
Art Institute of Chicago	CC0 for public-domain works	Impressionists, Homer, Poussin, Cassatt
SMK, National Gallery of Denmark	Public-domain works free to reuse, commercially too	Hammershøi, the Danish Golden Age
National Gallery of Art (Washington), Rijksmuseum, Cleveland Museum of Art, Getty	Open-access programmes for public-domain works (confirm each image's rights line)	Dutch interiors, Rembrandt, manuscripts

The law points the same way. In the US, *Bridgeman Art Library v. Corel* (S.D.N.Y. 1999) held that a faithful photograph of a public-domain 2-D artwork isn't itself copyrightable, and Article 14 of the EU's 2019 Copyright Directive says the same for reproductions of public-domain visual art. UK law is less settled, which is one more reason to take files straight from the museum's own open-access page and record its rights line on the Muse Card.

Scripture for the †

- **World English Bible:** public domain. Quote it freely, but if you change the text you may not call it the WEB (the name is trademarked). Used in this guide.
- **Brenton's Septuagint** (1851): public domain, and it's the Greek Old Testament the Orthodox Church reads, so it's the right one for Old Testament verses.
- **King James Version:** public domain in the US (Crown rights still apply in the UK).
- NKJV / *Orthodox Study Bible*, RSV, NABRE: in copyright, AMBER. They're generous with short quotations but have to be credited according to their own terms.
- Reading *references* (Luke 4:22–30) are facts and free to use. They can be read from an Orthodox calendar service such as orthocal.info, cross-checked against GOARCH's online chapel.

The canon wells

WELL	WHAT WE TAKE FROM IT
University of Dallas Core	The Literary Tradition sequence: epic (Homer, Virgil), Dante, Milton, Greek drama, Shakespeare, the novel (Austen, Melville, Dostoevsky, Faulkner), plus Plato, Aristotle, Augustine and Aquinas from the philosophy and theology cores.
Wyoming Catholic College	A four-year humanities sequence and more than thirty memorised poems , among them Hopkins's “God's Grandeur” and sonnets by Shakespeare, Donne, Wordsworth and Keats. A ready-made shelf of poems that last.
Columbia Literature Humanities	Wider range: Enheduanna, Sappho, Ibn ‘Arabi, Marie de France, Sor Juana, Montaigne. Good for the weekly balance rule.
Orthodox and Eastern wells	The Desert Fathers, the <i>Philokalia</i> , Ephrem the Syrian, Romanos the Melodist, Dostoevsky, and Cavafy (public domain in Greek).

The few worth paying for

Keep the amber list short and important. These are the voices your GS formation was built on, and the ones people will miss if they're absent:

AUTHOR	WHY	FIRST STEP
Mary Oliver	The tone Poiesis is named for: attention as prayer.	Permissions department of the publisher named on the copyright page of the specific book
Wendell Berry	Place, peace, work. ("The Peace of Wild Things" is in the booklet.)	Same: publisher's permissions
C. S. Lewis	Longing: "the something else of which they are only an echo."	The Lewis estate's licensing agent via the publisher
Marie Howe, Denise Levertov, Czesław Miłosz	Living faith in modern speech.	Publisher's permissions
Seferis, Elytis	Greek Nobel laureates; your heritage and a voice from outside the Anglophone world.	Their Greek publishers (named on the copyright page); then translate them ourselves

How to ask

1. Find the rights holder on the copyright page of the *edition* you'll quote.
2. Write a short request: the exact text; that it's shown for one day and then kept in an archive for registered users; the audience size; whether it's paywalled; that it's non-exclusive; worldwide; digital only.
3. Ask for a **season licence** (say, six poems a year) rather than one poem at a time. It's cheaper to administer for both sides.
4. File the signed permission with the Muse Card. Without paper, a work stays out.

A note on the booklet itself. Printing Mary Oliver and Rilke's translators for a school group is one situation; publishing them in an app is another. Borrow the booklet's *shape* freely, and credit the priest who made it on the Why page. Treat its modern poems as the first page of the licensing wishlist, not as content Poiesis already has.

The Muse Bank

A year needs **about 1,095 muses** (365×3). Nobody chooses a thousand works in a single sitting. They're gathered steadily into a bank, and each day draws on it. Start with **400 green works** before launch, which is enough for about four months with room to choose.

One card per work

Work · title, author, date written, date first published Slot · poem / passage / painting Text or image · the exact edition used, translator and translation date, page or line numbers, source link Rights · tier (green/amber/red) + the reason: “pub. 1893, author d. 1916”, “Met CC0”, “permission on file 3 Oct 2026” Proofed against · two sources, with initials ① Story · 2–4 true sentences about how the work came to be, with two sources	Words · 3–6 lowercase theme words it could carry (<i>familiar, ordinary, attention</i>) Links · feasts, readings, spine steps, and other cards it rhymes with Four tests · Encounter / Reality / Tension / Kinship, 0–2 each Go deeper · one question in the house voice Hard words · for the hover definitions (<i>similitude, chervil, brakes</i>) History · the dates it was shown, so it isn't repeated within three years
--	--

Three stages

Gather (one shared spreadsheet; no code needed) Anyone can suggest a card: curators, friends, eventually users through a “suggest a muse” link in the Notebook. It's cheap and fast, and nothing gets published at this stage.	Verify Rights checked and recorded; text proofed twice; ① story sourced twice; four tests scored. Only verified cards can be placed.	Place Cards go into the calendar. The season is drafted six weeks ahead, the week is locked two weeks ahead, and the letter is written the morning after.
---	---	---

The curator's calendar

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENS
Before each season	Meditate on the spine (section iii). Lay out the index-card path. List the season's great feasts and fasts. Mark the days where the feast will override the spine.
Six weeks out	For each day: read, circle, name (steps 1–3). Pencil in candidate triads from the bank. Note gaps and send them to Gather.
Two weeks out	Lock the week. Run the four day-checks and the weekly balance rule. Prepare images, hover words, ① stories and † verses.
Each night	Read what people wrote. Draft the morning letter. Note which works caught fire and which didn't, back on their cards.
Each season's end	Look back: which words recurred, which voices were missing, and which cards deserve an encore in three years.

Getting started: the first twelve weeks

Weeks 1–2	Set up the Muse Bank. Add the prototype's existing muses (Dickinson, Thoreau, Vermeer, Keats, Caravaggio, James, van Gogh, Rublev) and this guide's nine as the first cards.
Weeks 3–4	Meditate on the spines for the Nativity Fast and Lent. Write the index-card paths. Send the first three permission requests.
Weeks 5–10	Gather and verify 400 green cards, about 70 a week. Start the Poiesis translations of Rilke's letters.
Weeks 11–12	Place the first season. Run a week of real days with ten friends, a GS-sized test group, and read what they write.

Friday 25 September 2026

theme, revealed after all three: *familiar* †

ORTHODOX DAY

Repose of St Sergius of Radonezh (1392) · Righteous Euphrosyne of Alexandria · Martyr Paphnutius and companions

READINGS

Ephesians 4:17–25 · **Luke 4:22–30** (rejected at Nazareth)

CATHOLIC PARALLEL

Ecclesiastes 3:1–11 · Luke 9:18–22 (“Who do you say that I am?”)

1 • READ

In Nazareth they marvel
at his words, then shrink
him back to size.

→

2 • CIRCLE

“Isn’t this Joseph’s son?”
Nearness makes them
blind.

→

3 • NAME

familiar, the great thing
we walk past because we
know it.

→

SPINE • RILKE, LETTER 1

“If your everyday life
seems poor to you, do not
accuse it; accuse yourself.”

The saint rhymes with the theme: for years Paphnutius came to a monastery for counsel from a monk called Smaragdus, and only near the end of Smaragdus’s life learned that the monk was his own daughter, Euphrosyne. She’s kept for the letter, not shown on the page.

MUSE I • THE POEM

from *Aurora Leigh*, Seventh Book

Elizabeth Barrett Browning, 1856

... No lily-muffled hum of a summer-bee,
But finds some coupling with the spinning stars;
No pebble at your foot, but proves a sphere;
No chaffinch, but implies the cherubim:
And,—glancing on my own thin, veined wrist,—
In such a little tremour of the blood
The whole strong clamour of a vehement soul
Doth utter itself distinct. Earth’s crammed with heaven,
And every common bush afire with God;
But only he who sees, takes off his shoes,
The rest sit round it, and pluck blackberries,
And daub their natural faces unaware
More and more, from the first similitude.

① THE STORY · *Aurora Leigh* is a novel in nine books of blank verse, the life of a woman poet told in her own voice. Barrett Browning called it the most mature of her works. It was published in 1856, five years before her death in Florence. These lines are Aurora’s own account of what a poet is for: to see the burning bush in common things.

go deeper → Name one common bush in your day. What would it mean to take off your shoes?

GREEN Published 1856; author died 1861. Text: Book VII, as given by the Celebration of Women Writers edition (Univ. of Pennsylvania digital library). Excerpt marked with an ellipsis. Hover words: *similitude*, *vehement*, *daub*.

Also considered: Wordsworth, “The world is too much with us” (1807). It has the stronger friction (“It moves us not”), but the day needed a woman’s voice. Keep it in the bank for a Lenten *distraction* day.

“The Ethics of Elfland”

G. K. Chesterton, *Orthodoxy*, chapter IV, 1908

Because children have abounding vitality, because they are in spirit fierce and free, therefore they want things repeated and unchanged. They always say, “Do it again”; and the grown-up person does it again until he is nearly dead. For grown-up people are not strong enough to exult in monotony. But perhaps God is strong enough to exult in monotony. It is possible that God says every morning, “Do it again” to the sun; and every evening, “Do it again” to the moon. It may not be automatic necessity that makes all daisies alike; it may be that God makes every daisy separately, but has never got tired of making them. It may be that He has the eternal appetite of infancy; for we have sinned and grown old, and our Father is younger than we.

① THE STORY · Chesterton wrote *Orthodoxy* as a companion to *Heretics* (1905). A critic had complained that he attacked other people's philosophies without stating his own, and this book was his answer. He calls it “a sort of slovenly autobiography”: he describes setting out to invent a philosophy of his own and discovering that it had been there all along.

go deeper → *What in your ordinary day repeats? Could you say “do it again” to it and mean it?*

GREEN Published 1908; author died 1936. Text proofed against the Standard Ebooks edition. Hover words: *exult*, *monotony*.

Interior in Strandgade, Sunlight on the Floor

Vilhelm Hammershøi, 1901 · oil on canvas · SMK, National Gallery of Denmark, KMS3696



A colour study, not the painting. Replace it with SMK's open-access file.

① THE STORY · From 1898 to 1909 Hammershøi lived at Strandgade 30 in Copenhagen and painted the same rooms again and again: grey walls, white doors, sometimes his wife Ida seen from behind, often nobody at all. The subject here is simply light falling through a window onto a floor he walked across every day.

go deeper → *Describe a room you walk through daily as if you were seeing it for the first time.*

GREEN Painted 1901; artist died 1916. SMK releases public-domain works for free reuse. Record the file's rights line when it's downloaded.

familiar + tapping the cross opens:

Luke 4:22, 24 · “Isn’t this Joseph’s son?” ... “Most certainly I tell you, no prophet is acceptable in his hometown.” (World English Bible)

Link prompts for the threads

poem & passage	Barrett Browning’s blackberry-pickers and Chesterton’s tired grown-ups: are they the same people?
passage & painting	Hammershøi painted the same rooms for eleven years. Is that monotony, or “do it again”?
poem & painting (the arch)	Where is the burning bush in this empty room?
all three (the knot)	What makes the familiar invisible, and what gives it back?

Why these three pass

Three angles: the poem sees heaven in a pebble, the passage argues that repetition is joy, and the painting shows an empty room lit up.

Friction: Barrett Browning says most of us only pick blackberries; Chesterton says God never tires of the ordinary. Is the failure in the world, or in us? **Reveal:** nobody would guess *familiar* from the poem alone, but after the room it’s obvious. **Scaffold:** the day works without Nazareth. With Nazareth it cuts deeper.

The letter, Saturday morning

FROM THE POIESIS DESK · YESTERDAY’S WORD WAS *FAMILIAR*

In Nazareth they heard him speak and said, “Isn’t this Joseph’s son?” The nearness that should have opened their eyes closed them. Yesterday the Church also remembered Euphrosyne, whose father went to a monastery for years to ask a young monk for counsel and learned only near the end that the monk was his own daughter. Barrett Browning says most of us sit round the burning bush and pick blackberries; Chesterton says God has never got tired of making daisies. Somewhere between them is the room you walked through this morning.

“For to the one who creates there is no poverty, and no poor, indifferent place.” – Rilke, to a young poet, 1903

Rilke line: Poiesis translation of “denn für den Schaffenden gibt es keine Armut und keinen armen, gleichgültigen Ort” (letter of 17 Feb 1903). The letter would also quote two or three first impressions, with their authors’ consent.

Saturday

26 September 2026

theme, revealed after all three: *beloved* †

ORTHODOX DAY

Repose of the Holy Apostle and Evangelist John the Theologian

READINGS (FOR THE FEAST)

1 John 4:12–19 (“perfect love casts out fear”) · John 19:25–27; 21:24–25

CATHOLIC PARALLEL

Sts Cosmas and Damian · Ecclesiastes 11:9–12:8 · Luke 9:43b–45

1 • READ

A great feast, so the feast leads. John: at the cross, and as the witness who wrote it down.

→

2 • CIRCLE

“There is no fear in love.” And his name for himself: *the disciple whom Jesus loved.*

→

3 • NAME

beloved: not loving, but being loved, and what that does to fear.

→

SPINE • RILKE, LETTER 7

Written in Rome: “For one human being to love another...”

MUSE I • THE POEM

Love (III)

George Herbert, *The Temple*, 1633

Love bade me welcome: yet my soul drew back,
Guilty of dust and sin.
But quick-ey'd Love, observing me grow slack
From my first entrance in,
Drew nearer to me, sweetly questioning,
If I lack'd any thing.

A guest, I answer'd, worthy to be here:
Love said, You shall be he.
I the unkind, ungrateful? Ah my dear,
I cannot look on thee.

Love took my hand, and smiling did reply,
Who made the eyes but I?

Truth Lord, but I have marr'd them: let my shame
Go where it doth deserve.
And know you not, says Love, who bore the blame?
My dear, then I will serve.
You must sit down, says Love, and taste my meat:
So I did sit and eat.

① THE STORY · Herbert, a country parson at Bemerton, saw almost none of his English poems in print. Dying in 1633, he sent his manuscript to his friend Nicholas Ferrar: publish it if it might “turn to the advantage of any dejected poor soul,” otherwise burn it, “for I and it are less than the least of God’s mercies.” Ferrar published it that year. It went through eight editions by 1690. *Love (III)* is the last poem of “The Church,” the book’s central section.

go deeper → *Where have you drawn back from a welcome you didn't think you deserved?*

GREEN 1633. Spelling modernised from the first edition; punctuation varies between editions, so fix one and record it. Hover words: *slack*, *marr'd*, *meat*.

“Of Prayer, of Love, and of Contact with other Worlds”

Fyodor Dostoevsky, *The Brothers Karamazov*, Book VI, ch. 3 (g), 1880 · translated by Constance Garnett, 1912

Brothers, have no fear of men's sin. Love a man even in his sin, for that is the semblance of Divine Love and is the highest love on earth. Love all God's creation, the whole and every grain of sand in it. Love every leaf, every ray of God's light. Love the animals, love the plants, love everything. If you love everything, you will perceive the divine mystery in things. Once you perceive it, you will begin to comprehend it better every day. And you will come at last to love the whole world with an all-embracing love.

① THE STORY · These are the teachings of the dying Elder Zossima, written down by the young monk Alyosha. In May 1878 Dostoevsky's three-year-old son Alyosha died. Grieving, Dostoevsky went that summer to the monastery of Optina Pustyn and met Elder Ambrose, who became a model for Zossima. The novel was serialised from 1879 to 1880. Dostoevsky died in early 1881.

go deeper → *Pick one ordinary thing within reach. What would change if you loved it on purpose today?*

GREEN Garnett translation 1912; translator died 1946. Proofed against the CCEL edition. The Eastern Christian voice of the week.

Landscape with Saint John on Patmos

Nicolas Poussin, 1640 · oil on canvas, 100.3 × 136.4 cm · Art Institute of Chicago, 1930.500



A colour study, not the painting. Replace it with AIC's CC0 file.

① THE STORY · In his Gospel John never gives his own name. He is only “the disciple whom Jesus loved.” Poussin shows him old and exiled on Patmos, writing among the broken columns and obelisk of the classical world. It's one of a pair, with Saint Matthew as its companion, painted for a secretary to Pope Urban VIII. Jerome records that in extreme old age John had to be carried into the church at Ephesus and said only, “Little children, love one another.”

go deeper → *If you were known only by who loves you, what would your name be?*

GREEN Painted 1640. AIC releases images of public-domain works under CC0. Jerome: *Commentary on Galatians*, on 6:10.

beloved + tapping the cross opens:

1 John 4:18 · “There is no fear in love; but perfect love casts out fear, because fear has punishment.” (World English Bible)

Link prompts for the threads

poem & passage	Herbert's soul draws back; Zossima says “have no fear.” What exactly is the fear?
passage & painting	Every grain of sand, every ruined column: what does a love that reaches <i>everything</i> look like on a hillside?
poem & painting (the arch)	Love tells Herbert to sit down. John is sitting, writing. What does being loved make you do?
all three (the knot)	Is it harder to love, or to let yourself be loved?

Why these three pass

Three angles: the poem is a scene of receiving love, the passage is a command to give it, and the painting shows a man who took “beloved” as his name. **Friction:** Herbert can't accept love, while Zossima commands love for everything, even sin-stained things. Which comes first? **Reveal:** *love* would be too obvious; *beloved* turns it toward the reader. **Scaffold:** no one needs the feast of St John, but those who tap the cross find the Beloved Disciple waiting.

The letter, Sunday morning

FROM THE POIESIS DESK · YESTERDAY'S WORD WAS *BELOVED*

Yesterday the Church remembered John, who never wrote his own name in his Gospel, only “the disciple whom Jesus loved.” Jerome tells us that in extreme old age John had to be carried into church and would say only, “Little children, love one another.” When his disciples tired of it and asked why he always said the same thing, he answered that it was the Lord's command, and that if this alone were done, it would be enough. Herbert's soul drew back; Zossima said have no fear. Love doesn't argue us out of our fear. It sits us down and feeds us.

“To love is good, too: for love is difficult.” — Rilke, from Rome, 14 May 1904

Rilke line: Poiesis translation of “Auch zu lieben ist gut: denn Liebe ist schwer.” The same letter continues: “For one human being to love another: that is perhaps the most difficult of all that is laid upon us, the utmost, the last trial and test, the work for which all other work is only preparation.” (“Liebhaben von Mensch zu Mensch: das ist vielleicht das Schwerste, was uns aufgegeben ist...”)

Sunday

27 September 2026

theme, revealed after all three: **deep** †

ORTHODOX DAY

17th Sunday after Pentecost · 1st Sunday of Luke · Martyr Callistratus and companions

READINGS

2 Corinthians 6:16–7:1 · **Luke 5:1–11** (the great catch)

CATHOLIC PARALLEL

26th Sunday in Ordinary Time (Year A) · Ezekiel 18:25–28 · Philippians 2:1–11 · Matthew 21:28–32 (the son who said no, then went)

1 • READ

After a night of catching nothing, a carpenter tells fishermen where to fish.

→

2 • CIRCLE

“We worked all night and caught nothing; but at your word I will let down the net.”

→

3 • NAME

deep: going out again, into deeper water, after failing.

→

SPINE • RILKE, LETTER 3

“Ripening like the tree... patience is everything!”

This is the mission's “pure trial and error” day: the muse as something that comes after a fruitless night, and can't be forced to come.

MUSE I • THE POEM

“Thou art indeed just, Lord, if I contend”

Gerard Manley Hopkins, dated 17 March 1889 · first published 1918

Justus quidem tu es, Domine, si disputem tecum; verumtamen justa loquar ad te: Quare via impiorum prosperatur? Ț.

Thou art indeed just, Lord, if I contend
With thee; but, sir, so what I plead is just.
Why do sinners' ways prosper? and why must
Disappointment all I endeavour end?

Wert thou my enemy, O thou my friend,
How wouldst thou worse, I wonder, than thou dost
Defeat, thwart me? Oh, the sots and thralls of lust
Do in spare hours more thrive than I that spend,
Sir, life upon thy cause. See, banks and brakes
Now, leavèd how thick! lacèd they are again
With fretty chervil, look, and fresh wind shakes
Them; birds build – but not I build; no, but strain,
Time's eunuch, and not breed one work that wakes.
Mine, O thou lord of life, send my roots rain.

① THE STORY · Hopkins wrote this in Dublin in March 1889, worn out by examination marking and feeling he'd made nothing that lasted. He died that June, aged 44. His friend Robert Bridges held on to the poems and published them in 1918, almost thirty years later. The Latin epigraph is Jeremiah 12:1: a complaint to God that is also a prayer.

go deeper → *What have you worked at all night with nothing to show? Write the complaint honestly. Hopkins did.*

GREEN Written 1889, published 1918; poet died 1889. Text matches the Poetry Foundation edition. Hover words: *brakes* (thickets), *fretty chervil* (lacy cow-parsley), *thralls*. The friction poem of the three days.

“The Middle Years”

Henry James, short story, *Scribner's Magazine*, May 1893

“A second chance—*that's* the delusion. There never was to be but one. We work in the dark—we do what we can—we give what we have. Our doubt is our passion and our passion is our task. The rest is the madness of art.”

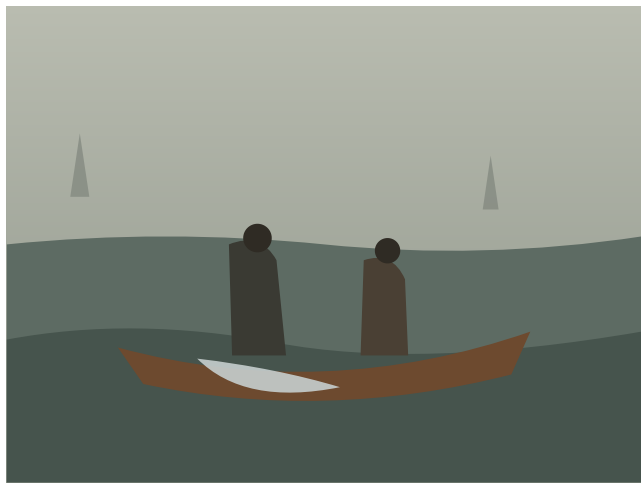
① THE STORY · Dencombe, an ageing novelist, is recovering at Bournemouth when the first copy of his new book arrives. Reading it, he sees at last what he might have done and longs for a second life to do it in. A young doctor who reveres his work stays at his side, and these are among Dencombe's last words to him. James was fifty when the story appeared. You named him in the mission: the writer whose imagination waits on something that *descends*.

go deeper → *James says there's no second chance. Simon got one in the same water where he'd failed. Which is true of your work?*

GREEN Published 1893; author died 1916. Proof against the 1895 collection *Terminations* (text on Wikisource). The passage is short but complete. Its whole weight is in these lines.

The Herring Net

Winslow Homer, 1885 · oil on canvas, 76.5 × 122.9 cm · Art Institute of Chicago, 1937.1039



A colour study, not the painting. Replace it with AIC's CC0 file.

① THE STORY · Homer spent 1881–82 in Cullercoats, a fishing village on England's north-east coast, painting the fishermen and their families. Back home, he settled at Prouts Neck, Maine. In 1885 he painted three great pictures of the fishermen's life, *The Fog Warning*, *Lost on the Grand Banks* and this one: two men in a small boat hauling in a heavy net of herring in the fog.

go deeper → *What net are you hauling right now, and who's in the boat with you?*

GREEN Painted 1885; artist died 1910. AIC CC0.

deep + tapping the cross opens:

Luke 5:4–5 · “Put out into the deep and let down your nets for a catch.” Simon answered him, “Master, we worked all night and caught nothing; but at your word I will let down the net.” (World English Bible)

Link prompts for the threads

poem & passage	Hopkins and Dencombe both want more time for the work. Which of them is closer to peace?
passage & painting	“We work in the dark.” Two men haul a net through the fog. What can you do without seeing?
poem & painting (the arch)	“Birds build – but not I build” ... and a net so full it's hard to lift.
all three (the knot)	What would you let down again, if someone told you where?

Why these three pass

Three angles: the poem is a raw complaint, the passage a hard-won creed, the painting an image of the catch. **Friction:** James denies a second chance; the Gospel, behind the †, gives one. **Reveal:** *deep* gathers the darkness, the doubt and the water together. **Scaffold:** every work stands without Luke 5, but the day as a whole *is* Luke 5 for anyone who taps the cross. **Spine:** it's Rilke's patience, taken to its limit.

The letter, Monday morning

FROM THE POIESIS DESK • YESTERDAY'S WORD WAS *DEEP*

“Master, we worked all night and caught nothing.” It could be a line from Hopkins, who wrote *birds build – but not I build* three months before he died, with almost none of the poems we now memorise in print. James's dying novelist says there is no second chance. Simon got one, at a word, in the same water where he'd failed all night. Homer's two men are still hauling in the fog. Whatever you let down this week, let it down again, a little deeper.

“It comes. But it comes only to the patient.” – Rilke, from Viareggio, 23 April 1903

Rilke line: Poiesis translation of “Er kommt doch. Aber er kommt nur zu den Geduldigen” (the summer that comes to the tree that doesn't force its sap).

To decide next

1. **Desktop theme reveal.** The † beside the theme word means desktop gains the same reveal-after-all-three as phones. Confirm, and log it as Round 8.
2. **Who curates?** Suggested: you as editor-in-chief, plus two or three “GS-style” guest curators for each season, each owning a week and signing the letters.
3. **Letter voice.** Does the letter quote users’ first impressions? That needs an explicit opt-in at the moment of writing (“may we quote you?”).
4. **Feast versus spine.** Proposed rule: great feasts and Sundays follow the reading; weekdays can follow the spine when the reading is thin.
5. **The Rilke translations.** Translate the ten letters yourself or commission a translator? Either way, the text becomes Poiesis’s own.
6. **Old-calendar users.** Users on the old calendar (Russia, Serbia, Athos) are thirteen days behind. Probably fine to ignore at launch; worth a line in Why.
7. **Crediting the priest.** A line on the Why page naming the School of Community booklet as the model, with his permission.

Sources

Calendar & readings. Orthodox readings and commemorations for 25–27 Sept 2026: orthocal.info (new calendar); St George Antiochian Orthodox Church, bulletin for 27 Sept 2026 (1st Sunday of Luke, 2 Cor 6:16–7:1, Luke 5:1–11). Catholic readings: catholicgallery.org (25, 26 Sept 2026); USCCB and Vatican News (27 Sept 2026). Scripture text: World English Bible, ebible.org (public domain; trademark note).

Texts. Barrett Browning, *Aurora Leigh* VII, digital.library.upenn.edu/women/barrett/aurora. Chesterton, *Orthodoxy* ch. IV, standardbooks.org. Dostoevsky, *Brothers Karamazov* VI.3(g), Garnett trans., ccel.org. Herbert, “Love (III)”, poetryfoundation.org and luminarium.org. Hopkins, poetryfoundation.org (poem 44404). James, “The Middle Years”, Wikipedia (Scribner’s, May 1893) and Wikisource, *Terminations* (1895). Rilke, *Briefe an einen jungen Dichter*, rilke.de (letters of 17 Feb 1903, 23 Apr 1903, 14 May 1904). Wordsworth, poetryfoundation.org.

Stories. Euphrosyne: Wikipedia, “Euphrosyne of Alexandria”. Herbert and Ferrar: Wikipedia, “Nicholas Ferrar”. Dostoevsky, Optina, Ambrose:

Wikipedia, “The Brothers Karamazov”. Jerome on John: M. W. Erickson, “Little children, love one another” (2024), citing Jerome, *Comm. in Gal.* 6:10. Hammershøi: Wikipedia. Homer: AIC exhibition archive (1937.1039) and Wikipedia, “The Fog Warning”. Poussin: Wikipedia, “Landscape with Saint John on Patmos”; Wikimedia Commons (AIC 1930.500).

Rights. Public Domain Day 2026 (works of 1930): Duke Center for the Study of the Public Domain; Internet Archive. Met Open Access (CC0, 492,000+ images): metmuseum.org. AIC CC0: Smithsonian Magazine (2018). SMK public-domain reuse: SMK Open (Medium). EU Directive 2019/790 art. 14: EUR-Lex. *Bridgeman v. Corel*, 36 F. Supp. 2d 191 (S.D.N.Y. 1999). Fair use: 17 U.S.C. §107.

Curricula. University of Dallas, “The Literary Core” and “Great Books of the Core”. Wyoming Catholic College, “Humanities”. Columbia College, “Literature Humanities”. Model: *Expect the Unexpected*, GS School of Community booklet (private).

Round 8 notes —